

IN CONTEXT

Commissioned concertos

The Concierto de Aranjuez was written by Rodrigo for the Spanish guitarist Regino Sáinz de la Maza. Its success prompted other virtuoso soloists to approach him with commissions. He also arranged the work for Spanish harpist Nicanor Zabaleta, who later commissioned the Concierto serenata for harp and orchestra from him.

Other of Rodrigo's commissioned works include the Concierto como un divertimento for cello for Julian Lloyd Webber; the Concierto pastoral for flute for James Galway; the Concierto Andaluz for the Romeros Guitar Quartet; and the popular Fantasía para un gentilhombre for the guitarist Andrés Segovia.

Joaquín Rodrigo was born in Sagunto on St. Cecilia's day, November 22, 1901. When he was only three years old, he was one of many children in the town who contracted diphtheria, which left him permanently blind. Soon after, the family moved to Valencia, where Joaquín attended school for the blind, and took his first music lessons on the piano and violin at the age of eight.

As a teenager, he had lessons in music theory with teachers from the Valencia Conservatoire, and began to take an interest in composition, using the braille system of musical notation to write his music, which he then dictated to a copyist, Rafael Ibáñez. Employed by the family as Joaquin's assistant, Ibáñez shared Rodrigo's love of music and literature and became his constant companion as well as amanuensis and secretary.